



Frozen Cliché

The book, like its subject, is breathtakingly beautiful. Period.

By Kaveree Bamzai

Jigme Khesar Namgyal Wangchuk is a mouthful for a country as tiny as Switzerland and a population of 7,50,000. Just as well then that he is officially being crowned the King of Bhutan and will henceforth be plainly referred to as His Majesty. Bhutan is a handsome glimpse into his quiet nation tucked away from civilisation as it were, despite being nestled between two very busy and bossy neighbours. Perhaps the overdose of testosterone has caused it to celebrate virtues such as gross national happiness. It's such curiosities that the book, despite its somewhat pedestrian text, manages to let slip. For instance, did you know there are no begging monks in Bhutan, or that the first known Europeans who visited the kingdom were Jesuit priests from Portugal in 1627, or that the country is home to the zomo, a cross between a cow and a yak? But there's not much to explain why Bhutan has never been colonised or invaded, or even how it continues to be so remote. Yet the photographs by Gunter Pfannmuller make the book fly, whether it is of the royal family gazing unblinkingly into the camera, its somewhat



(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP)
THREE OF THE FOUR QUEENS
OF BHUTAN; THE KING JIGME
KHESAR NAMGYAL; TAMSHING
LAKHANG MONASTERY

fierce-looking herders and farmers, or the country's pristine mountains touching seemingly digitally enhanced clouds. Seeing them commune with the sky you can see why Bhutan banned trekking in the sacred mountains unlike Nepal and Tibet. Who would want to injure such innocence? At its core though, the book, like its enigmatic subject, remains a cliché. It will look good on your coffee table. And it's what they call a great conversation starter, especially the amazing shoes the prime minister is sporting. No more. ■



BHUTAN
by WILHELM KLEIN AND
GUNTHER PFANNMULLER
Roli
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